Gotabaya. Always protective of its assets, the R&AW had warned Lasantha that the Sri Lankan regime might strike back. Lasantha told Faridi that he felt the same. ‘His apprehension was right. Just a few days before he was murdered, I had told him to avoid going out. He called me a day before he was killed to say that he was feeling suffocated at home and could not live in fear of government threats.’

The day Lasantha decided to go to his office, he phoned Faridi, who warned him not do so for the next couple of days at least. ‘But he laughed,’ said Faridi. ‘I was talking to him on the cell phone when he told me that two persons on a motorcycle were perhaps following his car and two others were backing them in another vehicle. I asked him to drive towards any police picket in the area. He couldn’t find one and kept repeating that he might be killed today. He shouted many times: "I can’t see a police station, what should I do now?” I tried to pull out details of the area to guide him towards a police station but then I heard his voice for the last time. He said, "They are here.” I froze. I knew that very moment that I had lost Lasantha,’ Faridi told me.

A day after Lasantha was killed, opposition leader Ranil Wickremesinghe alleged that the Sri Lankan intelligence service was responsible for assassinating Lasantha and that they reported to Gotabaya. Although this was a mere allegation from a political leader, international intelligence agencies operating in Sri Lanka were certain that the order to eliminate the journalist-editor had come from Gotabaya.

The murder of Lasantha hit the headlines all over the world and reminded the global community about the decades-old civil war in Sri Lanka.